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Dead Man

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Lee - Life after death, or death as life? Dead Man, postmodernism, and ontology - JCRT 3.2

Life after death, or death as life? *Dead Man*, postmodernism, and ontology

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The question of the meaning of human existence in the totality of Being, this fundamental question of philosophy, gains its true and practical importance through man's total discovery of death."¹ Only through death does life take on significance but, for many, the very fact of death removes the significance of life altogether. For Baudrillard "death is meaningless, civilised life as such is meaningless".² He writes that 'ours is a culture of death' and contemporary culture is formed out of an attempt to dissociate life and death. The dead have been excluded, unlike in the 'primitive' mind where the dead are part of the social, as in the Jarmusch film *Dead Man* (1996) Baudrillard's division of life and death can be questioned for not only does one involve the other but they can occur simultaneously in the same being as the fake William Blake shows in *Dead Man*. Baudrillard writes the repression of death in contemporary society leads to the repressive socialisation of life.³ The debate surrounding screen violence continues unabated, male violence along with female beauty being the most revered elements in American culture.⁴ In the majority of feature films male protagonists, other than in rare exceptions such as *Thelma & Louise* (Ridley Scott, 1991), are shown to be in control of death. In the film to be analysed here, despite the protagonist being a male killer, his control over his own death and that of others is questioned, as is death itself.

> The psychotherapists are caught up in contemporary culture and are forced to be a part of it knowledge. [^15]

Here, this psychology of self-knowledge is 'self-deception' but utopia and dystopia exist conc

> the activity of perception which it involves is real (the cinema is not a phantasy), but the

Nietzsche saw art as redemption via illusion[^22] and these representations of death can lead

> In Lacanian teaching representation and the death drive are connected by a fundamental link

Maraux's quotation relates to Blake travelling with himself as a dead man, even before he is v

The real and fake William Blake - Dead Man__: An Examen Of Unconsciousness_ ⁵

> 'Real' reality can not be apprehended as it is: an infinite, equally existent number of dis changing entities and events. To see the universe in those terms might be accurate, but would l

¹Jacques Choron, *Death and Western Thought*, trans. Ilsa Barea (London: Collier Books, 1963), p. 27.

²Max Weber, quoted by Jean Baudrillard, *Symbolic Exchange and Death*, trans. Iain Hamilton (London: Sage, 1993), p. 163

³Weber., pp. 127,147,131,130,133.

⁴Elizabeth Wurtzel, 'Murder in the doll's house', *The Guardian Weekend*, May 9 1998, p. 16.

⁵This section is titled thus, as opposed to 'an examen of consciousness' (a spiritual exercise taught by the Jesuits), as often the film is presented as an examination of myths stemming from the unconscious.

The question is, does it matter if this Blake is not the 'real' William Blake? That is, Blake

Notes

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